historical developments continue to inspire President Putin in his claims over Ukraine.

It was thus Russia which, by a twist of history and with the help of Orthodox Christianity, gradually became synonymous with Eastern Europe. This happened despite the fact that, for centuries, Russian influence did not reach further west beyond Ukraine and Poland and that, before World War II and its aftermath, Russians never ventured into Central Europe.

All this had political and social consequences for Eastern Europe proper, such as the late abolition of serfdom in the region. Also, the Orthodox tradition was primarily concerned with the heavenly and holy and much less with the affairs of this world. This too led to a growing gap in economic and social development between Central Europe and Eastern Europe proper.

Natural conditions made things even worse: east of Central Europe lay large swathes of sparsely inhabited lands. In contrast, in Western Europe, at the height of the Middle Ages, farming became very intensive (to keep up with the increasing demands of the densely populated areas of Western Europe) but there was little need for such intensification in ‘Eastern Europe proper’. In fact, even the gap between Western Europe and Central Europe is often explained by the fact that the West was increasingly turning to more sophisticated forms of agriculture (dairy and meat), as well as to non-agricultural economic activities, resulting in Central Europe becoming the granary of Western Europe. (Today, Ukraine and Russia are the granaries of a good part of the world, as the war in Ukraine has so clearly revealed.) Because of its proximity, it could still successfully manage to export and transport agricultural products to the West which – until the arrival of the railway – was not possible or viable for countries lying further to the East. To get going, ‘Eastern Europe proper’ lacked both an economic stimulant that was physically near enough and a philosophic ambition within its own culture. In the absence of both, it began drifting away from Central Europe, and also, of course, from its cultural roots in the south-east where the Ottomans now ruled.

I have already mentioned the growing economic gap between Eastern and Western Europe from the year 1000 and, in particular, from 1500 onwards. We have no estimates for individual Eastern European countries for that period. For the year 1600, the average GDP in Eastern Europe is estimated at 548 dollars, while that of Austria was already 837 dollars. The lands on